CONFIDENTIAL — INVESTOR OVERVIEW

LoadBoardGram

A direct AI freight platform —
no broker middleman, Uber-style

Project Overview · August 2026

1. Executive Summary

The North American loadboard market has run on a handful of entrenched players for decades — DAT Freight & Analytics and Truckstop.com. Both products solve the basic problem of "matching a load with an available truck," but do it mostly by hand: a dispatcher filters the list themselves, judges whether a rate is fair themselves, vets the counterparty themselves, and runs the negotiation themselves.

LoadBoardGram is a loadboard in the same class as DAT/Truckstop on core functionality (load and truck search, rate analytics, counterparty checks), but with a next-generation level of automation: AI matches loads, forecasts the market rate, scores counterparty risk, and takes over the routine parts of negotiation and paperwork.

The project's core strategic goal is to **remove the broker as a middleman from the logistics chain** and connect the shipper directly with the carrier. It's the same move Uber once made in the taxi industry: before Uber, a passenger called a dispatcher, the dispatcher manually looked for a free car and radioed the driver — Uber removed the dispatcher and connected passenger and driver directly through an app. LoadBoardGram aims to repeat that outcome in American logistics: replace the broker's role — finding a counterparty, pricing the rate, checking trustworthiness, agreeing on terms — with an algorithm and AI, leaving the human with only the actual hauling.

2. Problem & market opportunity

- **An unnecessary middleman.** The broker takes their own margin (typically 15–20% of the freight rate) for a function that's essentially search-and-match — exactly what an algorithm does well.
- **Manual load matching.** Dispatchers spend hours scrolling and filtering lists instead of receiving ready-made, relevant matches.
- **Opaque pricing.** Lane rates change daily; without good analytics, carriers and brokers negotiate "blind" and leave margin on the table.
- **Fraud and double-brokerage risk.** An industry-wide problem existing platforms only partially address — with a basic credit-history check.
- **Dated UX.** Leading platforms are technologically conservative: filter forms, no natural-language search or assistants.

These gaps leave room for a player that builds the same core functionality but with an AI layer on top of it — not as a bolt-on "feature," but as the product's core operating principle.

3. Product & vision

3.1 Core differentiator: a direct connection, no broker

DAT and Truckstop are platforms where a human still closes the loop between load and truck: a broker or dispatcher who manually picks the counterparty, negotiates the rate, and takes their own margin for the intermediation. LoadBoardGram removes that link: the platform itself matches shipper and carrier, itself sets a fair rate from market data, and itself checks both sides' trustworthiness — the same way Uber replaced the dispatcher with an algorithm and connected passenger and driver directly.

For the carrier this means a higher rate (no broker margin); for the shipper, a lower shipping cost and transparency. The platform monetizes not by withholding information or gatekeeping the intermediation, but through the technology that makes the direct match possible.

3.2 Product architecture

The platform combines three layers:

1. **Core loadboard** — a real-time load and truck marketplace, comparable in scope to DAT/Truckstop (search, filters, company profiles, history).
2. **AI layer** — smart matching, rate forecasting, risk scoring, document automation (section 5).
3. **Trust & compliance** — company verification, a reputation system, fraud protection — replacing the oversight function a broker traditionally provides.

4. Competitive landscape

Based on US market research, October 2026. Full company profiles and source links are in `docs/research/`.

4.1 DAT and Truckstop — the load-board leaders

DAT (Roper Technologies) is #1 by volume, with over 700k load posts a day. In 2024–2025 it bought tracking, factoring, and Convoy's technology (automated matching and bidding). Its live AI is ML load recommendations and market-rate analytics. **Truckstop** is #2 by volume but furthest ahead on AI: a voice assistant for search, carrier risk scoring, and automated document audit (rate con / POD / invoice). Both monetize through subscriptions ($42–469/mo) and both are broker-centric: brokers post most of the loads.

4.2 LoadHunt ($LHUNT)

Not a standalone loadboard but a browser extension for dispatchers that runs "on top of" DAT and Truckstop (load ranking, a profit calculator, automated emails to brokers), plus a young TMS. Live AI is minimal — most AI features are marked "coming soon". Monetized through subscriptions ($9–27 per dispatcher) and a utility token. Not a marketplace competitor, but it shows dispatchers will pay for an AI layer on top of existing boards.

4.3 The new wave: direct boards and AI agents

- **Doft** — closest to us in model: shippers post directly, "no broker markup"; an AI rate forecast and a voice AI agent that negotiates with brokers on the carrier's behalf. Its scale figures are self-reported only.
- **Amazon Relay** — the largest direct, broker-free board there is, but for a single shipper: Amazon itself.
- **Uber Freight** and **Loadsmart** — digital brokers running dozens of AI agents (30+ and 11 respectively), focused on large shippers.
- **HappyRobot** ($1.22B valuation, August 2026) and **FleetWorks** — AI negotiation and booking agents sold to brokers.
- **Highway** — the carrier-verification and anti-fraud leader; in 2025 it launched an exchange open only to verified participants.

4.4 What sets us apart

Differentiator	LoadBoardGram Direct marketplace	DAT Load board	Truckstop Load board	Uber Freight Digital broker	Loadsmart Digital broker	Doft Direct board	Amazon Relay Single-shipper board
Direct shipper ↔ carrier, no broker No broker margin: the shipper pays less, the carrier earns more	✓ Yes core of the model	✕ No brokers post	✕ No brokers post	✕ No Uber is the broker	✕ No broker margin	◐ Partial optional	◐ Partial Amazon only
Open to any small or mid-size shipper The big players focus on enterprise — small shippers still phone brokers	✓ Yes	◐ Partial by quote	◐ Partial $109–239 plans	✕ No enterprise	✕ No enterprise	✓ Yes free	✕ No Amazon only
Double brokering structurally impossible ~69% of market fraud is tied to double brokering — there's no middleman here to resell a load	✓ Yes by design	✕ No 19k fake loads (2025)	✕ No blocks after the fact	✕ No	✕ No	◐ Partial brokers post too	✓ Yes
AI works for the shipper and carrier, not a broker Almost all AI money in the market automates the broker's job rather than replacing it	✓ Yes all 3 AI features	✕ No for brokers	◐ Partial partly for carriers	✕ No the broker's own AI	✕ No broker's agents	✓ Yes for carriers	– N/a
Natural-language load search “Reefer out of Dallas under $900” instead of six filters — a lower bar for small carriers	✓ Yes LLM	✕ No	◐ Partial by voice (AVA)	– N/a	– N/a	– N/a	– N/a
Arrival estimate on the load card A realistic delivery window before pickup, without a GPS tracker	✓ Yes route + window	◐ Partial tracking, not a forecast	– N/a	◐ Partial tracking	◐ Partial tracking	– N/a	– N/a
In-platform AI negotiation agent The market is heading to bot-calls-bot over the phone; structured agent-to-agent bids are faster and fully logged	◷ Planned	◐ Partial Convoy auto-bidding	✕ No	✕ No fixed price	◐ Partial broker's agents	◐ Partial voice bot	✕ No
Trust scoring for both sides — carrier and shipper Everyone vets the carrier, nobody scores the shipper's ability to pay — and with no broker that's the carrier's #1 question	◷ Planned	◐ Partial identity check	◐ Partial carrier only	◐ Partial carrier onboarding	◐ Partial onboarding	◐ Partial FMCSA checks	◐ Partial carrier onboarding
AI price recommendation for the shipper Only differentiating combined with the direct model: with no broker, the shipper has to know the market price	◷ Planned	◐ Partial analytics for brokers	✓ Yes Rate Insights	✓ Yes fixed prices	✓ Yes ML quotes	✓ Yes rate forecast	– N/a

Legend: ✓ Yes ◐ Partial ✕ No ◷ Planned – N/a

> **Honest summary:** of 9 differentiators, **6 already work** — 4 as properties of the model itself, 2 as MVP AI features (natural-language search, arrival estimate). **3 are spec-only**: the negotiation agent, two-sided trust scoring, and price recommendation. Today our strongest differentiators come from the model; the AI edge becomes real once trust scoring and the negotiation agent are built.

> **Where we don't stand out (parity or behind):**
>
> - **Document processing** — Truckstop already runs document audit; ours is spec-only.
> - **Load matching** — DAT (ML), Truckstop, Uber, and Doft all have it; ours is a deterministic rule-based heuristic.
> - **Liquidity** — DAT has 700k+ loads a day, we have a demo. The main risk for any new marketplace.
> - **Payment guarantee and factoring** — DAT, Truckstop, Uber, Doft, and Amazon Relay all offer it; it isn't even on our roadmap yet. With no broker, who would normally guarantee the carrier gets paid, that's a critical gap.

> **Positioning:** the big players (DAT, Truckstop, Uber Freight, Loadsmart) have AI, but it works for the broker. Direct models exist only as a closed single-shipper board (Amazon Relay) or a small player (Doft). The niche of a direct marketplace for small and mid-size shippers, with AI working for the parties to the deal, remains open.

4.5 Prior attempts at "Uber for trucking"

The idea of removing the broker from the chain has already been tested in the market, and that track record is worth acknowledging honestly:

- **Convoy** — a startup that explicitly branded itself "Uber for trucking," raised over $900M from well-known funds and private investors, but shut down in October 2023 amid a freight-market downturn and its inability to raise further funding under those conditions. Its technology went to Flexport, and then to DAT in 2025.
- **Uber Freight** — Uber's own play in this space (since 2017). It technically connects shippers and carriers directly, but in practice still operates on digital-broker logic: it takes a margin per deal and never actually eliminated the intermediation function — only automated it.
- **TruckSmarter** — a free board with an AI dispatcher: 500k+ carriers and $16M raised in 2025, yet acquired and shut down in September 2026. A big user base without transaction revenue wasn't enough.

The takeaway for our strategy: the direct-connection idea is technically sound and market-tested — these companies failed not because the hypothesis was wrong, but because they

scaled on very thin margins without a sufficient AI layer to bring down the cost of verifying trust and risk, and without transaction-based monetization from day one. Our focus on AI for trust scoring, rate forecasting, and negotiation automation (section 5) is exactly what lets us hold onto the unit economics where our predecessors lost them.

5. Key AI capabilities

Feature	What it does	Value
Smart load matching	AI weighs route, deadhead miles, history, and carrier preferences to surface the best-fit loads	Less deadhead mileage, less time spent searching
Market rate forecast	Forecasts the lane's freight price days ahead, not just historical statistics	A stronger negotiating position
AI negotiation assistant	Runs the first round of contact with the counterparty and settles the rate within set bounds	Automates routine calls and back-and-forth
Counterparty trust scoring	Assesses non-payment or fraud risk from history and documents	Protection against double-brokerage
Document automation	Recognizes and processes BOL/POD/rate confirmation	Less manual work for dispatchers and accounting
Natural-language search	A free-form query instead of a filter form	A faster, more accessible interface
Arrival time forecast	ETA estimate accounting for traffic, weather, and driver hours-of-service limits	More accurate planning for the shipper

6. Business model

Revenue model: a subscription + take-rate hybrid — Uber-style, where the driver doesn't pay for access to the order list but a small percentage of each completed ride.

Tier	Indicative price	Audience
Base	$9.99/mo	Owner-operators

Pro	$14.99/mo	Small fleets
Business	$29.99/mo	Fleets and transportation-management teams

Take rate: a small percentage of the value of each successfully completed shipment matched directly on the platform — significantly below a traditional broker margin (15–20%), since part of the intermediation function is performed by AI rather than a human. This is the primary revenue driver as deal volume grows; the subscription covers access to the tooling (AI matching, analytics, document automation).

The pricing grid and take-rate figures are an illustrative starting point for validation; final numbers get refined from pilot results.

Initial customer acquisition strategy: launch a pilot program with a limited set of carrier companies on preferential terms to gather feedback and early case studies, in parallel with performance marketing (paid traffic acquisition) to scale the user base once the product hypothesis is validated.

7. Target audience & go-to-market

A two-sided model — the same shape as passenger and driver in Uber:

- **Shippers** — manufacturers, retailers, companies that regularly need to move freight; they get a direct, transparent price with no broker markup.
- **Carriers — owner-operators and small fleets** — the bulk of classic loadboard users, and the most sensitive to saving time and fuel and to a higher rate from cutting out the middleman.
- **Fleets and transportation-management teams** — run several trucks at once, and benefit the most from automated matching and negotiation.

Market entry starts with a pilot cohort inside an existing industry contact network, followed by expansion through paid acquisition and a referral program.

8. Roadmap

Phase 1 — MVP. Core loadboard (load/truck search, company profiles) + the first AI module (smart load matching). Launches in a narrow niche/region rather than nationwide at once — informed by Convoy's experience with the risks of premature scaling.

Phase 2 — Pilot. Launch with a limited cohort of shippers and carriers, direct matching with no broker, gathering feedback, iterating on pricing and UX.

Phase 3 — Expanding the AI features. Rate forecasting, trust scoring, document automation.

Phase 4 — Scaling. Paid user acquisition, a referral program, expanding geography/segments.

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